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OBLEDO VISITS LEARNING CENTER CALIF. WELFARE CHIEF CHALLENGES KISSINGER ON "REFUGEES"



MARIO OBLEDO (second from left), Secretary of California's Health and Welfare Agency, at the Community Learning Center with Ms. ELAINE BROWN (far left), Executive Director of the Educational Opportunities Corporation (EOC); Ms. PATSY FULCHER (third from right), Mr. Obledo's administrative assistant; Ms. ERICKA HUGGINS (far right), director of the Intercommunal Youth Institute; DAVID G. DU BOIS (fourth from right), Editor-in-Chief of THE BLACK PANTHER Intercommunal News Service; and (second from right) a local welfare

official.

(Sacramento, Calif.) - Mario Obledo, Secretary of California's Health and Welfare Agency, the largest and most progressive in the country, has suggested that Secretary of State Henry Kissinger visit Oakland, to see firsthand conditions there before finalizing plans to dump some one million Vietnamese "refugees" on California.

In a telegram to Kissinger on April 24, the newly appointed Mexican-American California welfare chief requested an opportunity to personally meet with the secretary of state "within 48 hours at any place convenient to you" to discuss the matter.

Obledo pointed out to Kissinger that California has the largest number of unemployed (952,000) of any state in the union, that California has 2.4 million residents receiving some form of medical or welfare assistance, that California has four million residents at or near the poverty level "and 20 million residents who are taxed at close to the maximum tax acceptable in a free enterprise system."

Obledo's telegram was sent as he finalized plans to take the entire agency administration, including eight of the highest ranking Health and Welfare officials in the state, into the city of Oakland to hear firsthand the problems and complaints of Oakland citizens.

Oakland, with a nearly 50 per cent Black and Mexican-American population, has an unemployment rate almost double the national rate. Mr. Obledo is setting up desks for his administrators at the Oakland Employment Development Department offices and inviting Oakland residents to come and tell them "about any problems they might have with state government."

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